

FILTER FEEDER

PTERODAUSTR

Unique feeding style

Paleontologists think *Pterodaustro*'s jaws were well adapted for a process known as filter feeding. The long teeth on its lower jaw were arranged in a pair of comblike rows that sifted out tiny animals such as brine shrimp and algae from the water. Once *Pterodaustro* had trapped its prey in its beak, it swallowed its victims whole.

***Pterodaustro* was a relatively small pterosaur** (a flying reptile) with an elongated skull and an upturned beak. However, its fossils reveal that unlike some pterosaurs, it was not toothless. While its lower jaw housed hundreds of bristlelike teeth, adapted for filter feeding, the upper jaw was lined with smaller ones. These modified teeth may have evolved to help *Pterodaustro* strain the small aquatic animals and algae that made up its diet from shallow waters.

HIGHLY
SPECIALIZED
TEETH

The long beak could hold plenty of prey.

GROOVED JAW

Pterodaustro's bristlelike teeth were not just unique in appearance, they also grew differently. Unlike the teeth of other pterosaurs, which grew in sockets, these teeth developed out of a groove in the lower jaw.

Jaw groove